

3 Wrong from the Start Operation Pawan, 1987

Political and diplomatic miscalculation that went into India signing the 1987 peace accord with Sri Lanka pitch-forked the 20,000-strong Indian Peace Keeping Force against the very LTTE it had trained to fight the Lankan forces. "Operation Pawan is a chapter of Indian military history that will contain none of the honour and glory of a victorious campaign," said INDIA TODAY in 1987.



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

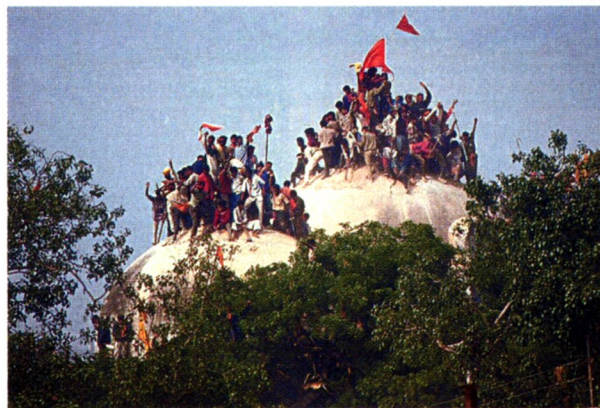
4 News of a Kidnapping Rubaiya Sayeed's Abduction, 1989

In the two-decade-old tenacious and violent separatist movement in Kashmir, it is reckoned as a turning point—for the worse. Days after Mufti Mohammed Sayeed took over as the Union home minister in the V.P. Singh government, his daughter Rubaiya, a 23-year-old medical student, was abducted from the streets of Srinagar by militants of the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front. They demanded, and secured, the release of five of its incarcerated members. "Politically, the episode established the alienation of a section of the Valley's youth," wrote INDIA TODAY in December 1989.

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5 Easy Target Rajiv Killed, 1991

It was a high-profile political assassination born out of a complex plot but simple security failures. On May 21, 1991, Rajiv Gandhi fell to a female suicide bomber, Thenmozhi Rajaratnam, of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam, at Sriperumbudur, 40 km from Chennai, when he was campaigning for the Lok Sabha. "If only the basic procedures provided for in the blue book on VIP protection were followed, the tragedy could have been averted," said INDIA TODAY in June 1991. At the election rally venue there was no perimeter security, no barricading, no metal detectors and no sniffer dogs.



PRASHANT PANJARI

6 When Right Went Wrong Babri Masjid Demolition, 1992

On December 6, 1992, an unprecedented religious frenzy whipped up by an array of Hindu right-wing organisations brought down the medieval Babri Masjid, while the state, represented by 25,000 paramilitary personnel, including the elite NSG, stood like spectators. It was a monumental failure of both the intelligence and security establishments. The widespread riots that followed the demolition rent the nation's social fabric. "The damage to India's polity and the reputation of the law enforcers was irreparable," wrote INDIA TODAY in December 1992.

7 High Treachery The Kargil War, 1999

For the country's intelligence and military establishment, lulled into complacency by the cross-border warmth generated by prime minister Atal



Bihari Vajpayee's Lahore bus journey in February 1999, the nasty surprise sprang up three months later from the heights of Kargil and lasted for six weeks. "By the time the army got its act together, more than 100 soldiers had been killed, many of them mowed down because the enemy's firepower was grossly underestimated," wrote INDIA TODAY in September 1999.